

The founding couple had 11 children. Their children almost all had children, too. Three of them had 7 children each.¹

Second, the family decided not to split things up, but to have a system of “everything for everybody,” in which all the children of the founding couple shared equally all the wealth (shares in active companies, mostly).

This was a break with tradition in a couple of respects: Usually, the people who actually build the wealth get a larger share of it. And, typically, in the north of France, although wealth may be partitioned equally, women are usually given real estate and men are given businesses (on the theory that they will take the risks and rewards of active enterprise, while women will be happy to have the solidity of real estate).

This decision, made decades ago, made a big difference. It kept the whole family focused on the family business because they were all in it together. Among the second generation, many did not play an active role in the business, but often, their children, who had as many shares in it as the children of the active siblings, did. The family could draw on three generations of talent. It still does.

Also, as new businesses were created, they were spun out from the center—with “everything for everybody” still the guiding principle.

Third, the family makes a huge effort at *affectio societatis*, the conscious reinforcement of the family’s original principles and philosophies. The founders’ business—and other—ideas are rehearsed, recalled, and recycled into each generation.

Fourth, they are careful not to get sidetracked by wealth or fame. They keep out of the public eye. There are few, if any, photos of the family members. The general public doesn’t know who they are or what they look like.

Fifth, they do not sell. They’ve had many chances to “monetize” their businesses. They’ve rejected each one systematically. Their businesses double every seven years.

Sixth, the family requires all shareholders, who are also uncles, cousins, and other relatives, to play a role. Even if they are not active in the business, they are supposed to inform themselves about how the business is doing and to help sustain the founding principles of the enterprise.